

Episode 142: *The Tatami Galaxy* Colour Design Notes Volume 3

There's a cat that has semi-permanently settled in a park near our house. Nicknamed "Char Cat." It's neither red nor three times faster than normal. It's called "Char Cat" because whenever you try to pet it, it always threatens with "Char~" (laugh). But then it'll meow "nya~n" in a cute voice.

This cat seems to be still a kitten or young cat, but apparently was abandoned by someone. So it's interested in people but seems wary somewhere, hence the "Char~." My wife and I had been concerned about this cat for a long time, but recently a neighbourhood cat lady took it under her care and apparently made a nice sleeping spot in her yard(?).

But this Char Cat still sometimes sleeps in the park. It roams around freely, sometimes getting food from strangers, and when satisfied, returns to its sleeping spot.

My wife and I have long wanted to keep a cat, but if we were to have one, due to various circumstances, it would probably become what's called an "apartment cat" that never goes outside. But is that really a good thing?

Living without knowing the outside world, without any worries, always together with owners - that's probably happiness in its own way, but living like Char Cat, freely walking around outside and touching various things, is probably also happiness.

I personally think cats should ideally be allowed to go outside freely, and that this is their natural way of being. Both cats and humans should be like that, I think.

What exactly is happiness for a cat? Watching Char Cat makes me think about various things like that.

Anyway.

This week's "*The Tatami Galaxy* Colour Design Notes" continues. Episodes 6-8 from DVD & Blu-ray Volume 3, finally entering the second half.

Episode 6: English Conversation Circle "Joy English"

Storyboard/Direction: Natsume Shingo, Animation Directors: Nishigaki Shoji & Asano Naoyuki, Colour Direction: Otsuka Natsuko

Episodes 6 through 8 are what I'm arbitrarily calling "'I's Romance Fantasy Trilogy." They revolve around "I's" romantic(?) situations with three women: Hanuki-san, Kaori-san, and Keiko-san. Three stories coexist and intertwine on a single timeline, then branch off toward their respective conclusions partway through.

The beginning of these three stories commonly starts from the toilet in Hanuki-san's apartment. "It would be good to visually tie them together, and with strongly impressive screens (colours)," I thought. So during the Episode 7 art board meeting, I made a proposal. "How about an emergency situation feeling, with a bright red toilet like emergency lighting?" Thus, the common image for the opening scenes of Episodes 6-8 became "a bright red toilet like emergency lighting."

Why was it during Episode 7's art board meeting instead of Episode 6's? Because at that point, Episode 7's work far exceeded Episode 6's, so we prioritised Episode 7's meeting (laugh).

So Episode 6, "Hanuki-san." For this episode, I aimed for somewhat flashy colours. As the first of the three episodes, I consciously wanted to add flashiness for impact. The following Episode 7 would be a deliberate, focused presentation centered on "I's" four-and-a-half-mat room revolving around Kaori-san, so I wanted to create contrast in that sense too. Incidentally, Episode 8 would raise the tension again and reach a conclusion.

With that thinking behind Episode 6's colour design (色彩設計), the first half progresses relatively quietly, but after drinking one glass of wine, a switch flips and it suddenly becomes high-tension.

This "drinking contest with Jogasaki-senpai" scene. Director Natsume also ordered "make it gradually become strange colours," so I tried to create the feeling of gradually getting drunk and then breaking down(!) with colours. Like Episode 5's "brainwashing scene," I first created character colour samples and explained them to the colour direction staff, then had them create everything according to the tension of the incoming rough animation. I'm only creating the design blueprint for the screen's colouring - it's each episode's colour direction staff who follow it and further expand on it.

The "brain conference" - I was already laughing when I first received the character designs (laugh). Since it could become too raw if done wrong, we made this colourfully pop-coloured too. Hanuki-san's runaway pink mode literally made both the art and characters pink (laugh). This area was really fun to work on (laugh).

And "Johnny." First there was the animation character design, then we decided colours like other characters, then had it made into Flash.

Episode 7: Circle "Hero Show Enthusiasts"

Storyboard/Direction/Animation Director: Mihara Michio, Colour Direction: Suzuki Hisae

Episode 7 proceeded on an incredibly proper schedule, and we completed meetings around the same time as Episode 4, which had started quite late. So colour direction staff Suzuki-san was putting colour direction into Episode 7 cuts even before Episode 4, which was delivered first.

"Kaori-san's" Episode 7 takes a deliberate approach. About Kaori-san herself: "This person isn't 'human,' so please change the main line colour from human characters so it's recognisable," said Director Yuasa. She first appeared in Episode 2, but we tried various things with Episode 2's director Yokoyama-san included and decided on it.

Character colour decisions involved me first creating colours, then showing them to Director Yuasa, character designer Ito-san, and the director in charge of the episode where that character first appears. Various ideas came up during decisions, sometimes resulting in 180-degree direction changes from the initial meeting.

This story is also told through past recollections and present, but in the latter half, after shaking off temptation from Hanuki-san's apartment toilet and returning to the four-and-a-half-mat room, it rides the current timeline. Everything before that is past recollection. And then elopement. Here's the first appearance of Real Otsu. It's a bit hard to tell in the night colour-changed scene, but Real Otsu has the same skin colour as "I." You can understand this area by watching the final episode's last scene - not only the facial features but also the skin colour of the Otsu that "I" saw was such an evil existence (laugh).

Kaori-san comes to "I's" four-and-a-half-mat room. Based on past recollections, there are art distinctions for different times of day - day, night, night without lighting, morning - and we change cel colours accordingly. However, since these are combined cuts (so-called same position) with the same layout depicting multiple time periods, colour direction and colouring were quite difficult. During rushes check, there were several "wait, what?(sweat)" moments. And such things would increase even more in subsequent episodes.

From when he embraces Kaori-san and flees under the Kamogawa bridge, we actually change Kaori-san's main line colour to the same human character colour as "I." Around here, for "I," Kaori-san is no longer a doll but already human. Then when Jogasaki comes and delivers a kick, he literally wakes from the dream, and simultaneously we return Kaori-san to doll status.

Incidentally, the Mochiguman show at the opening scene, with children's "Reform yourself!" chants. This might be scarier than "Honwaka" depending on how you think about it (laugh). Oh yes, about the Mochiguman in the Mochiguman show - originally there are five colours and five bodies, but actually only four appear in this scene. But there are five colours. Why did this happen? There was some reason for it, but...

Episode 8: Reading Circle "SEA"

Storyboard: Shimizu Hiroshi, Direction: Fujise Jun'ichi, Animation Director: Ito Nobutaka, Colour Direction: Akimoto Yuki

The last of "I's Romance Fantasy Trilogy" is the correspondence story with Keiko-san. "How about if 'I's' delusions in the letters gradually become more realistic?" was the conversation during the art board meeting. I think during the meeting we talked about "how can we differentiate reality from delusion?" and the discussion progressed toward making the delusion scenes look unlike the *Tatami Galaxy* style we'd had up to that point.

The animation also has sparkling eyes! in a realistic(?) "I," so we aimed for a nice feel by placing it over backgrounds. The decisions for those cuts also followed the flow of having the colour direction staff create colours from the animation's atmosphere, with me checking. So basically it was super-short decisive battle work after backgrounds came up. Well, not just for this scene - in *The Tatami Galaxy*, almost all scenes were in that situation. Moreover, schedules were getting quite tight, and from Episode 8 onward, it was quite a fragrant situation (bitter laugh).

Also, from around Episode 8, using processed scenes and cuts from previous episodes increased dramatically. Until then, there were scenes used repeatedly throughout the series as-is (sometimes with additions) like the castella-gorging scene in the four-and-a-

half-mat room or the conversation scene with Otsu at the Okinawan restaurant, but from Episode 8 onward, the usage became somewhat different.

As I wrote earlier, these three episodes from Episode 6 tell three stories progressing in parallel on a single timeline, so structurally, screens from previous episodes would be used repeatedly. However, they're not used as-is - we change the colour of the entire screen including backgrounds to give meaning to those scenes. Since familiar scenes and cuts appear repeatedly, the purpose is to visually organise the increasingly complex timeline intersections. For example, the series of "Mochiguman Show" scenes that appeared in Episode 7. These appear twice in Episode 8, but we change colours each time, and change the colour-changing method differently both times.

The first time is used as fictitious "Actually..." that "I" wrote in a letter. Only "I" including Mochiguman is normal colour, while everything else (including newly added conversations of children in the bus for Episode 8) is gloomy blue-tinted monotone. With somewhat negative implications, arranged in heavy colours. The second time appears as Akashi-san's recollection. Since it's from Akashi-san's viewpoint, Akashi-san and "I (Mochiguman)" are coloured. Others are bright monotone. Since it's Akashi-san's good memory, it's arranged brightly and softly.

All such processing was actually left entirely to me. I was allowed to work on everything including backgrounds. I'd create processed screens thinking about directional meaning, then have the director and direction staff check them. I'd try changing colour direction for cels and backgrounds, or make only specific characters different colours, preparing photography materials with such processing, then having them re-shot with basically the same time sheet.

Generally, it's common to add colour processing by applying filters to the entire screen during photography or editing, but actually, we "colour people" aren't very happy about that. However, in *The Tatami Galaxy*, there was almost none of that. Even when processing during photography, we were consulted by the photography staff.

This work increased more and more in subsequent episodes, and I actually handled everything single-handedly until the final episode. But you know, it was enjoyable work! As a designer (設計), you delegate each episode to the assigned colour direction staff, so you can't really directly touch the main footage to participate in each episode yourself. Being able to touch the screen like this without infringing on the colour direction staff's work divisions made me very happy.

(10.10.26)